CHAPTER 19

Documenting Ruby

Documentation is a critical part of communicating across teams. Code comments can help share the intent of the developer, or can be a way to explain constraints on the code that might not be clear from just reading code. It's not enough just to add comments to the code; it's also useful to be able to publish those comments onto the web or to be consumable by your editor or command-line tools like ri or irb.

Two tools in the Ruby ecosystem are used for converting code comments into external documentation: RDoc and YARD. Ruby comes bundled with RDoc, which is used by Ruby itself to document the built-in Ruby classes and modules. Those who like a more formal, tag-based scheme might want to look at YARD (http://yardoc.org). We'll cover both in this chapter. As YARD is mostly a superset of RDoc, we'll cover RDoc first, and then talk about YARD's extensions.

Documenting with RDoc

RDoc does two jobs. Its first job is to analyze source files. Ruby, of course, but it will also analyze C files and Markdown files. Within those files, RDoc looks for information to document. Its second job is to take this information and convert it into something readable—usually HTML or Ruby's ri documentation format. Let's look at an example.

Take the following simple file:

rdoc/example/counter.rb

```
class Counter
  attr_reader :counter

  def initialize(initial_value = 0)
    @counter = initial_value
  end

  def inc
    @counter += 1
  end
end
```

Going into that directory and running rdoc will create an entire doc directory with HTML files. Here's what one of the files looks like: